AI651: Deep Learning for Space, Time and Graphs

Assignment 2

Question 1: River Forecasting Proposal; Question 2: Motion or Memory?

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Question 1

River Forecasting Proposal

My proposal is a small model with a lot of structure in it. There is one grid that holds every source, a temporal encoder that runs on each place separately, and four rounds of message passing along the directed river graph. Every edge of the graph has a learned lag kernel, so the model estimates the transport time itself instead of me guessing it. The reasoning comes from the first experiment in the companion notebook, where a model that cannot see its neighbour cannot use what the neighbour knows. A river forecaster has the same problem, and giving it the graph is the same fix.

There is no data for this catchment, so the design is argued from what the question tells us: the four hops between the dam and S4, the travel times quoted in the tutorial, the fact that travel times change with river conditions, and the experiments in the companion notebook. In Section 4.6 I run one small sanity check on a synthetic river that I generated with Claude Code (the prompt is in the declaration at the end). Those numbers only show that the design trains and behaves the way I expect. They say nothing about the real river, and I do not use them anywhere else.

1. Architecture diagram

The whole system is one tensor. I stack every place and every channel on a common 10-minute grid, so the model never has to align the sources by itself:

Grid	a $30 \times 6 \times 4$ grid, B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 4 for a batch
Places	Dam, S1, T1, S2, S3, S4 (6 rows)
Time	24 observed steps $+$ 6 forecast steps (30 columns)
Channels	[level, observed?, rain, release] (4 channels)
Forecast	4 stations $\times$ 6 steps, B $\times$ 4 $\times$ 6 levels in metres

1.1 The sources and how they are combined

- **Levels at S1–S4 and T1.** One value every 10 minutes, with noise, some missing readings and some late ones. Each goes into the level channel of its own row, and a second channel marks whether the reading exists.
- **Rain at R1 and R2.** I bin these into 10-minute totals and put them in the row of the place they drain into: R1 in the S2 row and R2 in the S3 row (assumption A4).
- **Reservoir.** Recorded releases go in the release channel of the Dam row for the observed columns. The announced schedule for the coming hour goes in the same channel for the six forecast columns.

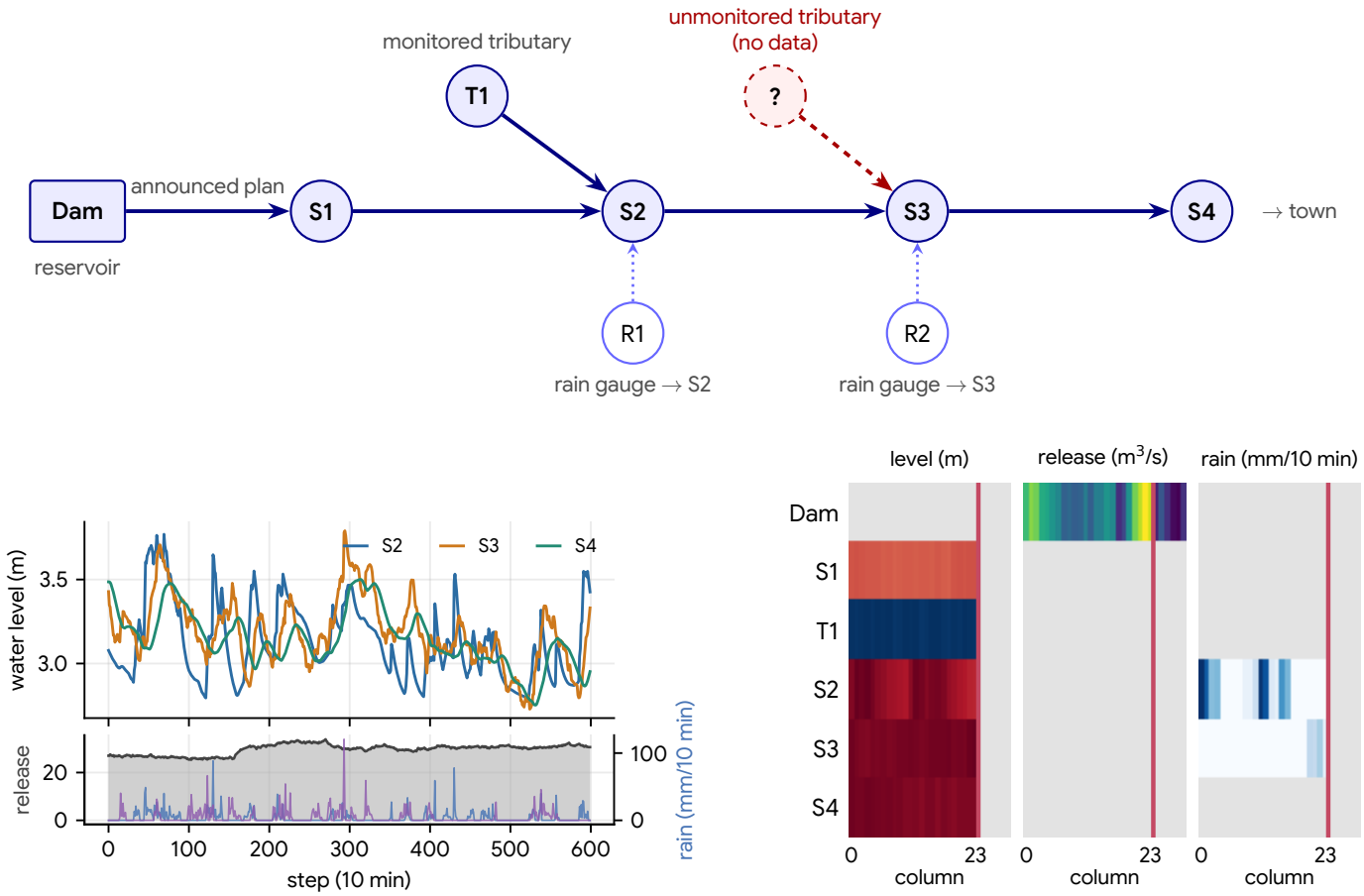


Figure 1. The catchment and the grid. **Top:** the river as a directed graph. Solid arrows are flow; T1 joins between S1 and S2, the unmonitored tributary (dashed, no data) joins between S2 and S3, and the rain gauges (dotted) are folded into S2 and S3. **Bottom left:** a stretch of the synthetic river used for the sanity check, where a change in the Dam release reaches the stations later. **Bottom right:** the grid the model sees (24 observed and 6 forecast columns). Grey cells hold no data. The red line is the forecast origin; to its right the only non-empty content is the announced release plan in the Dam row.

Nothing else goes in. In particular, no future level and no future rainfall reaches the model, because the forecast columns are empty and flagged as not seen, except for the announced plan. The rule is simple: if I would not know it at issuance time, the model cannot use it.

1.2 The three blocks

Alignment, projection and reshaping. Three things change shape between the grid and the output:

- **Alignment** happens once, when the grid is built. Rain is binned onto the same 10-minute clock as the levels. The last observed level of each station is carried forward through any gap and kept separately as y_0^s. The announced schedule is written into the six forecast columns of the Dam row, one column per future step.
- **Projection** from 4 channels to $d{=}64$ features happens in the stem. A learned place embedding of the same width is added, so the encoder can treat the dam differently from a gauged station.
- **Reshaping** happens twice inside the encoder. The grid is viewed as $B \times 6$ sequences of length 30 with 64 channels, convolved along time, and folded back.

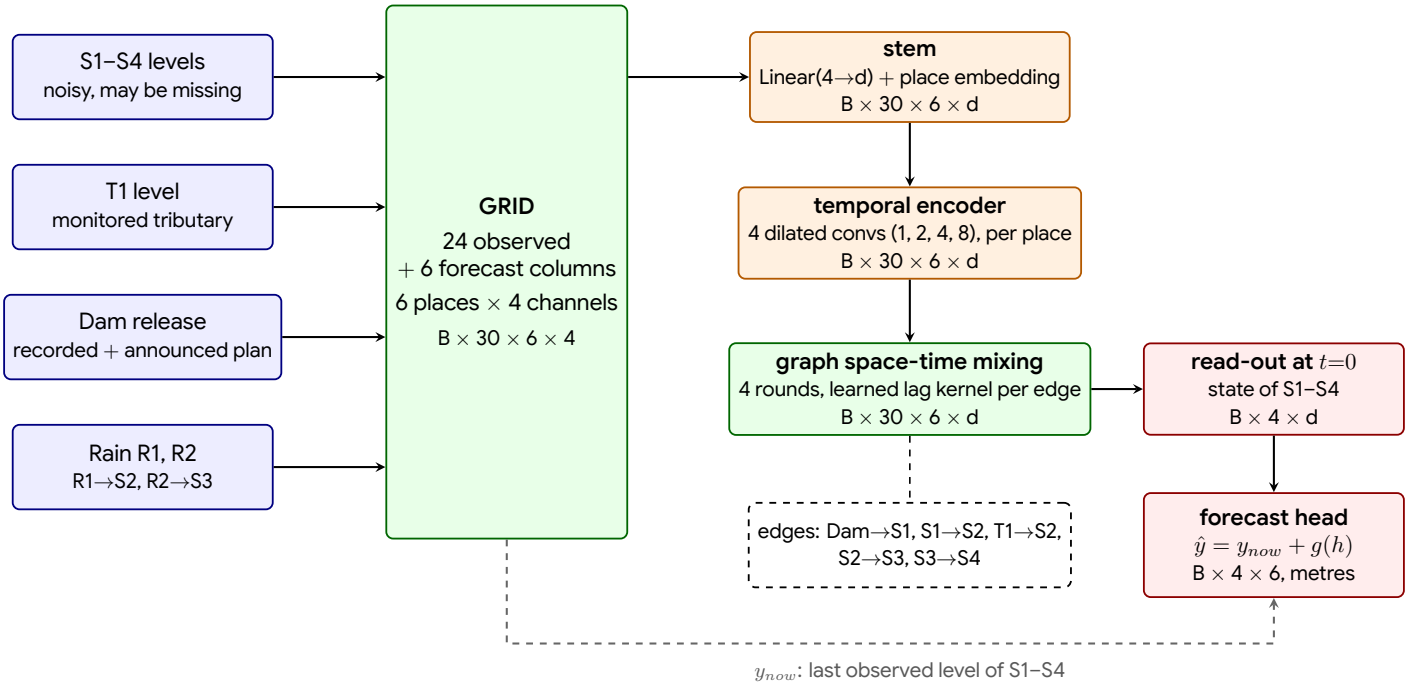


Figure 2. The three blocks. The grid is the only place where the sources meet. The temporal encoder runs on each place separately with shared weights and a learned place embedding, so the four stations share what they have in common while the dam can still behave differently. The graph stage is the only place where one place can see another.

1.3 How far a forecast can reach

A forecast can only use what has a path to it. The temporal encoder has a radius of $1 + 2 + 4 + 8 = 15$ steps around the read-out index. Each round of message passing moves information one hop along the river, and each edge can take its message from any lag in a window of 12 steps. So a message can cross the four-hop path with a lag of up to 44 steps. This means the S4 forecast can still be moved by the dam's release from 59 steps back, by S1 from 48, by S2 from 37, by S3 from 26 and by S4's own history from 15.

The dam is four hops from S4, which is why the graph mixing has four rounds. With fewer rounds the dam's release could not reach S4 at all. The reach (59 steps) is also much larger than the 24-step window I feed in, so the window is the limit and not the network. If the authority tells me the real transit is longer than I assume, I widen the window and nothing else changes.

2. Assumptions

The question gives us some facts and leaves the rest open. The facts are: 10-minute sampling; four main stations plus a monitored tributary; two rain gauges with stated locations; a reservoir with recorded releases and announced future schedules, with announcement and effective times; and station locations, river connectivity and distances along the river. It also says what is not supplied, which is precise travel times and the inflow of the unmonitored tributary, and that future rainfall and future water levels are not available at issuance.

Everything in the table below is my own assumption. For each one I give the reason and what it changes in the design.

#	I assume	because	therefore in my design
A1	a station reports every 10 minutes unless it is flagged missing	the question says levels are recorded every ten minutes	one grid column per 10 minutes, plus a channel recording whether the reading exists
A2	a missing reading is unknown, not zero	a water level of zero is not physically possible in a flowing river	the level cell and the flag are both set to zero, so a gap can never be read as a real zero
A3	a late reading arrives 1–3 steps late	reporting delays are not specified	the grid carries the stale value, the flag stays one, and the corrected reading enters the next window
A4	R1 drains into the S2 catchment and R2 into the unmonitored stream	the tutorial hints this, and R2 sits above the unmonitored stream	the rain channel of the S2 row carries R1 and the S3 row carries R2
A5	the announced schedule is valid for the whole coming hour at issuance	the question says schedules are announced before each forecast is issued	the plan occupies the six forecast columns of the Dam row
A6	the dam may not execute the plan	the question asks about differences between scheduled and actual releases	the plan is an input and not a constraint, and the recorded past releases correct it (Section 5.4)
A7	travel times are not constant and get shorter when the river is in flood	the question says travel times can change with river conditions	a learned lag kernel per edge instead of a fixed lag, so the model estimates the delay and I do not have to guess it
A8	the history window is 24 steps (4 hours)	the dam is four hops from S4 and the tutorial's figure puts one reach at about 50 minutes, so the dam-to-S4 transit is around 2–3 hours, and the window has to cover that plus the hour being forecast	24 observed columns, and the architecture's reach (59 steps) is not the limit
A9	each gauge has a stable datum	no datum information is supplied	the model predicts the change from the last observed level, but the raw level is still an input, so absolute levels and flood thresholds are not lost
A10	only part of the unmonitored tributary's inflow is explained by R2	its catchment is unknown, and part of it will never be observable	R2's rain is an input proxy, the rest is treated as irreducible (Section 6.1), and I ask for a gauge
A11	water does not flow upstream	the illustration shows the river flowing in one direction	the graph edges are directed, so an upstream station cannot read a downstream one
A12	the record is at least one year of 10-minute data	the record length is not specified	about 52,000 windows but only of the order of 10^2 independent flood events, so the model is small and the structure does the work
A13	the measurement noise is 1–2 cm and 1–2% of readings are missing	not specified	the observed? flag is an input, and training injects dropouts so the model has seen gaps
A14	all four stations are forecast together and on the same clock	the service issues one forecast for four stations	one shared model with one head and per-station normalisation

Table 1. The assumptions, each with the reason and what it changes in the design.

3. Forecasting task and data specification

3.1 The task

- **Issuance.** Every 10 minutes, at $t = 0$.
- **History.** 24 observed steps of 10 minutes, which is the previous 4 hours. These are columns $0, \ldots, 23$ of the grid, with column 23 the current step.
- **Horizon.** 6 steps of 10 minutes, which is the next hour. These are columns $24, \ldots, 29$, and steps $t = 1, \ldots, 6$ of the forecast.
- **Output.** 24 numbers: the level at each of S1, S2, S3, S4 for each of the 6 future steps.

The window is not a free choice. The dam is four hops upstream of S4 and the tutorial's sketch puts a single reach at about 50 minutes in calm conditions, so the dam-to-S4 transit is roughly two to three hours. A four-hour window covers that plus the hour being forecast, with some margin. It also covers the slow end of the range, because travel times get shorter in flood (A7). A shorter window could cut off the part of the upstream signal that is still on its way downstream.

3.2 The data

name	shape	axes	source and coverage	at issuance
Inputs				
grid X	B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 4	(batch, time, place, channel)	4 h of history plus the 1 h horizon, for 6 places	yes, except the future levels
level	B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 1	(batch, time, place)	S1–S4 and T1 every 10 min; the 6 forecast columns are empty	observed columns
observed?	B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 1	(batch, time, place)	1 if the reading exists, 0 if the value is a gap	observed columns
rain	B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 1	(batch, time, place)	10-min totals of R1 (S2 row) and R2 (S3 row)	observed columns
release	B $\times$ 30 $\times$ 6 $\times$ 1	(batch, time, place)	recorded releases in the Dam row, announced plan in the forecast columns	yes, both
last level y_0^s	B $\times$ 4	(batch, station)	last observed level at S1–S4, carried forward through gaps	yes
Outputs				
$\hat{y}$	B $\times$ 4 $\times$ 6	(batch, station, step)	water level in metres at S1–S4 for $t = 1, \ldots, 6$	no

Table 2. Every input and output. The grid is the only tensor that mixes places; the model never has to align two sources itself.

3.3 Alignment

All the sources are on the same 10-minute clock, so alignment is about putting each source in the right cell. Nothing is resampled.

- **Levels and releases** are already on the clock. A reading that did not arrive is flagged, and the last good reading is carried forward into y_0^s, so the residual head always has a reference level.
- **Rain** is a total over the interval since the previous reading. I bin it into 10-minute totals, so a 30-minute accumulation is spread over three columns instead of landing in one.

- **The plan** is a schedule and not a measurement, so it is indexed by step. The value announced for $t+1$ goes into column 24, $t+2$ into column 25, and so on.
- **Stations** are places, so the S3 level at one step and at the next step sit next to each other in time and in the same row.

The one thing that is not free is space. Stations are not on a lattice. They sit on a chain with uneven distances, so I give the model the graph instead of a matrix of neighbours (Section 4.4).

4. Model computations and design justification

4.1 Notation

- $i \in P = \{\text{Dam, S1, T1, S2, S3, S4}\}$ are the places, and $s \in \{\text{S1, S2, S3, S4}\}$ are the forecast stations.
- t indexes 10-minute steps. A forecast is issued at $t = 0$ and covers $t = 1, \dots, 6$.
- $L = 24$ is the history window, $H = 6$ the horizon, and $d = 64$ the width.
- $x_{i,t} \in \mathbb{R}^4 = [\text{level}, \text{observed?}, \text{rain}, \text{release}]$ is a grid cell, $y_{s,t}$ is the true level at station s, and y_0^s is its last observed level.
- $G = \{(\text{Dam, S1}), (\text{S1, S2}), (\text{T1, S2}), (\text{S2, S3}), (\text{S3, S4})\}$ is the river graph. It has 5 directed edges, and the dam is 4 hops from S4.

4.2 The blocks

(1) Per-place temporal encoder. This is one stack of dilated causal convolutions, applied to every place with shared weights, plus a learned place embedding $E_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$:

$$z_{i,t} = E_i + W_e\, x_{i,t}, \qquad z_{i,t} \leftarrow z_{i,t} + \varphi(\mathsf{LN}(W_\ell *_{d_\ell} z_{i,\cdot}))\,,$$

for $\ell = 1, \dots, 4$ with dilations $d_\ell \in \{1, 2, 4, 8\}$.

The output is $Z \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times 30 \times 6 \times d}$. The dilations give a radius of 15 steps, well inside the 24-step window. I share the weights across the four stations because they behave alike, and the place embedding lets the dam be different, since it is the one place that is not a gauged station.

(2) Graph space-time mixing. This is $R = 4$ rounds along G. Every edge has a learned kernel over $W = 12$ lags:

$$m_{i,t} = \sum_{\tau=0}^{W-1} \alpha_e^{(r)}(\tau)\, W_r\, z_{j,\,t-\tau} \quad \text{for each edge } e = (j \to i), \qquad z_{i,t} \leftarrow z_{i,t} + m_{i,t} + b_e,$$

$$\alpha_e^{(r)}(\tau) = \frac{\exp(\ell_{e,\tau}^{(r)})}{\sum_{\tau'} \exp(\ell_{e,\tau'}^{(r)})} \quad \text{with } \ell_{e,\tau}^{(r)} \in \mathbb{R} \text{ learned},$$

Important point here: the transport time is a parameter of the model and not a constant that I fix in the design. The question does not give travel times and says they change with the river, so a model that needed them as input would be guessing. With the kernel, the model puts its own weights over the lags, and whoever runs the system can print those weights and check them.

(3) Read-out and forecast head. I take one state per station at the forecast origin and predict a residual on the last observed level:

$$h_s = z_{s,0} \in \mathbb{R}^d, \qquad \hat{y}_{s,k} = y_0^s + g_k(h_s), \quad k = 1, \ldots, 6,$$

where g is a two-layer MLP. The residual keeps the numbers well scaled and makes the missing-data case well defined. It does not throw away the absolute level though, because the raw level is still an input to the encoder, and a flood warning depends on an absolute threshold.

(4) Objective. The training loss is the MAE in metres,

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{24} \sum_{s=1}^{4} \sum_{k=1}^{6} \left| \hat{y}_{s,k} - y_{s,k} \right|,$$

I use it because MAE in metres is what the service will be judged on: how far off is the level that the operator is told about.

4.3 Physical assumptions and learned mappings

Some parts of the model are physics that I assert, and the rest are numbers the model has to find. **Asserted:** the river is a directed chain with uneven spacing, water does not flow upstream, the dam is four hops from S4, R1 belongs to the S2 catchment and R2 to the unmonitored stream, and the announced plan may be wrong. **Learned:** how much a level moves given a change in the upstream level (the message matrices), how far back the useful upstream signal is (the lag kernels), and how a level, its trend and the releases combine into a forecast (the encoder and the head).

I do not let the network discover the catchment from the data. With a year of data and a few dozen independent floods there is not enough evidence to learn the topology, and a model that picks up a non-causal dependency would fail during a flood it has not seen before, which is exactly when it matters.

4.4 Why a graph and not a convolution over the grid

The grid has 6 rows, so I could have used a space-time convolution over the (time, row) axes instead of message passing. I did not, for three reasons.

- **Rows are not a lattice.** The rows are (Dam, S1, T1, S2, S3, S4), so a 3-tap kernel over that index connects S1 to T1, but T1 is a side stream and not a neighbour of S1 on the main river. The companion notebook makes the same point for its toy sensor line: adjacent indices can be very far apart physically, so the neighbours have to follow the geometry. Here the geometry is the graph, and the authority gives us the distances along the river, which a convolution over row indices ignores.
- **Stacked convolutions read upstream.** A 3-tap kernel mixes the row above as well as the row below, so after two layers a station's forecast depends on stations downstream of it. Water does not flow that way.
- **Directed, not symmetric.** A convolution treats both sides of the kernel the same. In a river the upstream and downstream neighbours are not interchangeable: the dam's release says something about S1, but S4 says nothing about the dam.

4.5 How the sources reach each forecast

The graph tells us what can reach what, so I can say how each source affects the forecast at a station s:

- **Reservoir.** The release reaches S1 almost immediately and S2 within about half an hour, so for those two the announced plan and the recorded releases matter directly, and the graph carries them. For S3 and S4 the dam's effect arrives hours later, outside the horizon.
- **Monitored tributary T1.** It joins between S1 and S2, so its level enters S2's forecast and, one round later, S3's and S4's.
- **Unmonitored tributary.** It joins between S2 and S3 and is not measured at all. The only handle on it is R2's rain, which is why the rain channel is in the S3 row.
- **Rain.** R1 drains into S2, so R1's 10-minute totals enter the S2 forecast directly and reach S3 and S4 one and two rounds later. R2 drains into the unmonitored stream, so it reaches S3 and S4.

The most useful upstream signal is the upstream station's current reading and not the wave still on its way. S4's level is a lagged version of S3's, so S3's current reading tells the model what S4 is about to do. That is why I expect the lag kernel to put weight on short lags, and why the graph path matters most for the most downstream station.

4.6 A sanity check on a synthetic river

There is no data, so I generated a small synthetic catchment and trained a few variants on it, just to check that the design trains and does what I intended. The prompt I gave Claude Code is in the declaration at the end. The simulator it produced is a kinematic-wave chain with the properties listed in the question. I changed it afterwards: I slowed the storage down because the levels it first produced moved unrealistically fast, and I made the travel times depend on flow. I use it only in this section.

variant	MAE (m)	S1	S2	S3	S4
persistence (no learning)	0.0375	0.0180	0.0587	0.0489	0.0243
per-station ridge, univariate	0.0372	0.0184	0.0583	0.0480	0.0239
per-station model, no spatial path	0.0308	0.0175	0.0448	0.0424	0.0187
this design (graph + learned delay)	**0.0259**	0.0157	0.0420	0.0361	0.0099
space-time conv over the row index	0.0249	0.0136	0.0421	0.0359	0.0080

Table 3. Sanity check on the synthetic river: one-hour-ahead MAE in metres, 3 seeds. The absolute numbers depend on the simulator and mean nothing on their own. Only the ordering matters.

Looking at Table 3, three things stand out. The per-station model without a spatial path is clearly worse than the graph design (0.0308 vs 0.0259 m), which is the companion notebook's argument on the river: a model that cannot see the upstream cannot use it. The gain is concentrated at the downstream stations, and S4 improves by about half (0.0187 to 0.0099), which is what the argument in Section 4.5 predicts. The learned lag kernels also put most of their weight on lags of 0 to 40 minutes instead of on the physical transit times. This is what I expected, since the model is using the recent upstream reading and not the wave still in transit.

The last row is not the one I picked. The space-time convolution over the row index scores slightly better on this toy (0.0249 vs 0.0259), but I would still not choose it because of the reason in Section 4.4: it can read downstream stations, and a river does not work that way. The gap is inside the noise of three seeds, so I made the choice on the physics.

5. Operation and exceptional conditions

5.1 Missing observations

A missing reading is not a zero level, so I do not fill it in as one. The level cell is zeroed, the `observed?` cell is set to zero, and the encoder can tell the two cases apart. The model is trained with injected dropouts, so it has seen gaps before.

I keep the flag as an input instead of just filling the gap, because a gap does not hurt every forecast equally. S4 leans on the upstream's current reading, so a gap at S3 or S4 hurts S4 the most. S1 leans on the dam, so a gap in the Dam row hurts S1 the most. A model that was only given a carried-forward value would not know which of its inputs to trust.

5.2 Delayed observations

A late reading is carried in the grid as the stale value with the flag still set to one, so the model can learn how much a stale reading is worth. It is still information, so I did not add a separate imputation stage. The flag and the stale value already let the model discount it, and imputation would add a failure mode of its own.

I do not re-issue a forecast when a late reading lands. The service runs every 10 minutes, and a re-issue would break that cadence for whoever consumes the forecasts. The corrected reading goes into the next window, 10 minutes later (A3).

5.3 Announced future releases

The announced schedule is the only future information the model gets, and it sits in the Dam row of the six forecast columns. Since those columns hold nothing else, the temporal encoder is allowed to look forward across them. This is safe because they contain only the plan and the flag, so looking into them cannot leak a future level.

5.4 When the dam does not do what it planned

Since the plan is sometimes wrong, and the model has to cope with that. I use two separate mechanisms.

- **Recorded past releases correct the plan.** The Dam row carries the actual release for the observed columns, so the model always knows what the dam really did, and only the future part of the plan is uncertain.
- **The model is trained with a noisy plan**, so it learns how much to trust it instead of trusting it blindly.

I keep the releases in their own row instead of spreading them over the stations, because a channel that means something different at every place is easy to get wrong.

5.5 The ten-minute cycle

The service issues a forecast every 10 minutes. The model is a single forward pass of a 72,000-parameter network on a $B \times 30 \times 6 \times 4$ grid, and the input for one forecast is only $24 \times 6 \times 4$ numbers. On the GPU I trained it on, 3,000 training steps take about 90 seconds, so one inference pass is far inside the 10-minute budget, and even on a laptop CPU it takes a fraction of a second.

So compute is not the risk, data is: a station that stops reporting, a plan that is not announced on time, or a release regime the model has not seen. The flag and the correction mechanism handle the first two. For the third, I use a small model and a learned delay instead of a hard-coded one.

6. Uncertainty, limitations, and additional information

6.1 The unmonitored tributary

This is the biggest uncertainty, and the one we have the least control over. The tributary joins between S2 and S3 and is not measured, so nothing in the inputs tells the model how much water is coming in. R2's rain is the only proxy. It is a proxy for the catchment and not for the stream: the routing from rain to inflow is unknown, and part of the stream's flow is groundwater or snowmelt that no gauge would predict.

The forecast impact is mostly at S3 and, with a delay, at S4. I respond in three ways. First, R2 is in the rain channel of the S3 row, which is the only handle on that catchment. Second, the model is told which readings are missing, so it can lean on the rest of the catchment's behaviour instead of the stream. Third, and most important, this is the one limitation the authority can actually remove, so it is the first request in Section 6.4.

6.2 Travel times that change

Travel times are not given and they change with river conditions, so I treat them as unknown. Three things protect the model:

- **The delay is learned and not assumed** (Section 4.2), so a wrong guess about the travel time cannot hurt, and a river that runs faster in flood does not need a second model.
- **The window is sized for the slowest case**, so none of the upstream signal falls outside the grid.
- **The reach is larger than the window** (Section 1.3), so a longer transit only needs a wider window and no change to the architecture.

What remains unresolved is that I sized the window from the tutorial's sketch and not from a measurement on this catchment. The real dam-to-S4 transit has to come from the authority. If it is much longer than three hours, L grows.

6.3 Limitations

- **No real data.** Every number here comes from a synthetic river or from the question. The design is argued from the facts in the question and the companion notebook, and the sanity check only says that the model trains and that the spatial path does something.
- **No uncertainty estimate.** The service needs to say how much to trust a forecast. A collection of seeds gives a small gain in accuracy, and its disagreement is much smaller than the error, so it is not an error bar.
- **One horizon, one catchment.** The value of the upstream grows with the horizon, and a longer forecast would change the window and the reach together.
- **Unknown record length.** A year of 10-minute data is about 52,000 overlapping windows but only a few dozen independent flood events, so the data-to-parameter ratio in a real deployment is much tighter than in my sanity check. A 72,000-parameter model is at the edge of what such a record supports.

6.4 Additional information I would ask for

- **A gauge on the unmonitored stream between S2 and S3.** This is the request that is the most important! The tributary is the dominant error term at S3, and no amount of modelling can substitute for a measurement of it. Without it the system still works, using R2's rain as the proxy, but S3 keeps an error floor that no architecture removes.
- **The actual travel times, or the distances and a velocity.** This is the one number that would let me size L correctly instead of conservatively. Without it the system still works, since the delay is learned and the window already covers the slowest case.
- **At least one year of the record, with the gauges' datum and their outage history.** Without the record the model cannot be fitted at all, so this is the one request the system cannot do without. The outage history would also let me fit a per-station quality weight instead of the binary flag.

Generative AI Declaration

In accordance with the course policy on generative AI, I declare that I used an AI coding assistant (Claude Code) for this question.

The prompt I used to generate the synthetic data is written below. It produced a Python module that simulates a river on a 10-minute clock. I edited its output afterwards: I slowed the storage down because the levels it produced first moved unrealistically fast, and I made the travel times flow-dependent so that they get shorter in flood.

> Build a synthetic river for a design study. Directed network: Dam $\rightarrow$ S1 $\rightarrow$ S2 $\rightarrow$ S3 $\rightarrow$ S4, a monitored tributary T1 joining at S2, and an unmonitored tributary joining between S2 and S3. Two rain gauges: R1 drains into the S2 catchment, R2 drains into the unmonitored stream. The reservoir release is recorded in the past and announced for the coming hour, and the announced plan is sometimes not what actually happens. Travel times shorten when the river is in flood. Sampling is every 10 minutes. Add measurement noise, occasional missing readings and occasional late readings. The target is the true level at S1–S4 one hour ahead.

The AI It wrote the synthetic-river simulator and the training harness for the sanity check in Section 4.6, and it produced the table and the figures in this report from the results it saved.

I designed the system: the grid, the per-place temporal encoder, the four graph rounds with a learned lag kernel, the residual head, and the MAE objective.

Question 2

Motion or Memory?

The Setup

Data and task

As per the manual, aftering loading Moving MNIST I split videos by index: 0–7,999 for training, 8,000–8,999 for validation, and 9,000–9,999 for testing. Frames are converted to float32 and divided by 255 so intensities lie in $[0, 1]$. The model sees 5 frames and predicts the next 5; at normal speed a window starting at frame t is

$$X = (x_t, \ldots, x_{t+4}) \qquad Y = (x_{t+5}, \ldots, x_{t+9})$$

I evaluate with $t = 1$ (input frames 1–5, target frames 6–10) unless stated otherwise.

Transformations

Three transformations are applied to every frame of both input X and target Y:

- Mirror M: $(Mx)[i, j] = x[i, 63 - j]$. The digit appearance changes since digits are not symmetric.
- Rotation R: 90° anticlockwise via `torch.rot90`. The digits change appearance even more.
- Speed-up ($k\times$): keep every k-th frame, so digits move further between the frames the model sees.

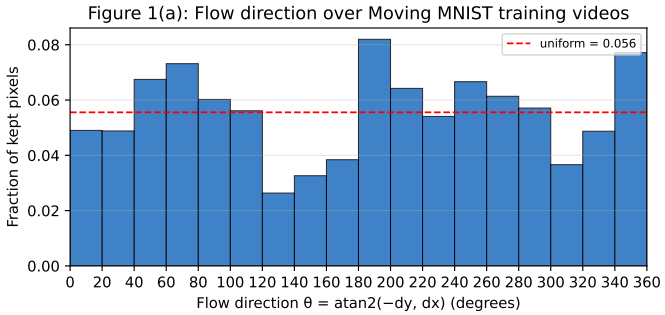
Mirror and rotation give the 8 symmetries of the square $G = \{R^a, MR^a : a = 0, 1, 2, 3\}$. For speed $k \in \{1, 2, 3\}$, a window is $X = (x_t, x_{t+k}, \ldots, x_{t+4k})$ and $Y = (x_{t+5k}, \ldots, x_{t+9k})$, keeping only target frames ≤ 20.

Checking the transformation and window functions

I ran checks (a)–(h) with the same transform and window functions used by the experiments, on the random video x and the marker video p defined in the handout. All rows match. The maximum absolute differences in (a)–(c) are exactly 0.0 and `torch.equal` returns `True` in each case.

Check	Expected	Yours
(a) max $\lvert M(M(x)) - x\rvert$	0	0 (`torch.equal True`)
(b) max $\lvert R^4(x) - x\rvert$	0	0 (`torch.equal True`)
(c) max $\lvert MRM(x) - R^{-1}(x)\rvert$	0	0 (`torch.equal True`)
(d) bright pixel of $M(p)$ (frame, row, column)	$(7, 10, 43)$	$(7, 10, 43)$
(e) bright pixel of $R(p)$ (frame, row, column)	$(7, 43, 10)$	$(7, 43, 10)$
(f) $1\times$ input / target frames	1–5 / 6–10	1–5 / 6–10
(g) $2\times$ input / target frames	1,3,5,7,9 / 11,13,15,17,19	1,3,5,7,9 / 11,13,15,17,19
(h) $3\times$ input / target frames	1,4,7,10,13 / 16,19	1,4,7,10,13 / 16,19

Table 1. Checks on the mirror, rotation and speed-window functions. Rows (a)–(c) report the maximum absolute difference and the result of `torch.equal`; rows (d)–(e) report the bright-pixel coordinates; rows (f)–(h) report the input and target frame numbers returned by the window function at $t = 1$.



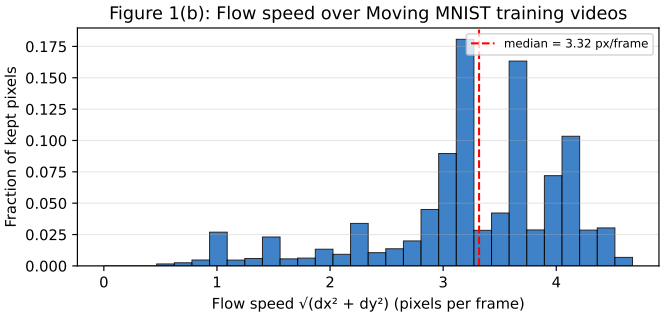


Figure 1. Optical flow over the first 50 Moving MNIST training videos, pooled over 950 consecutive frame pairs. (a) Histogram of flow direction $\theta = \text{atan2}(-dy, dx)$ in degrees on $[0°, 360°)$ with 18 bins of $20°$; the dashed line marks the uniform level $1/18$. (b) Histogram of flow speed $\sqrt{dx^2 + dy^2}$ in pixels per frame; the dashed line marks the median. 103,050 pixels were kept (intensity > 0.2 in both frames and flow magnitude > 0.5 pixels). Median speed: 3.32 pixels per frame.

Q2.1

Based on Figure 1(a), mirrored and rotated trajectories would already be familiar in their motion statistics. The histogram is broad and covers every direction: all 18 bins are populated, and the bin fractions lie between about 0.026 and 0.083 around the uniform level $1/18 \approx 0.056$. The histogram is not exactly flat because the underlying velocities are discrete and the estimate uses only 50 videos, but no direction is systematically absent. Mirroring reflects the histogram ($\theta \mapsto 180° - \theta$) and rotation shifts it by $90°$; the data-generation process is square-symmetric, so these transformations map the training motion distribution onto itself. What changes is the digit appearance.

From Figure 1(b), a typical digit moves at 3.32 pixels per frame (median over 103,050 kept pixels across 950 frame pairs). Running at $2\times$ corresponds to roughly twice that speed in pixels per frame (about 6.64), and $3\times$ to roughly three times (about 9.96). Optical flow is unreliable where the two digits overlap, but overlaps are brief and localised, so they cannot bias the pooled histograms enough to change this conclusion.

Q2.2

For each transformation:

- Mirror M: changes the digit appearance only. The motion statistics (speeds, bounce behaviour, direction distribution) are unchanged, just reflected.
- Rotation R: changes the digit appearance only. Motion statistics are unchanged, just rotated.
- Speed-up ($k\times$): changes the motion statistics only (digits move further between frames). Digit appearance is unchanged.

This makes the three transformations useful as a controlled experiment because each one isolates a single factor. Mirror and rotation perturb appearance while leaving motion statistics intact, so any failure under them must come from the model tying its motion rule to what the digits look like. Speed-up perturbs motion statistics while leaving appearance intact, so any failure under it must come from the model not having seen or not being able to reach that kind of motion. Comparing the three tells us whether the model's errors are driven by appearance, by unfamiliar motion, or by architectural reach.

ConvLSTM Baseline

Architecture

Each input frame undergoes `pixel_unshuffle(4)`, folding each 4×4 pixel patch into channels: a $1 \times 64 \times 64$ frame becomes $16 \times 16 \times 16$. Two ConvLSTM layers follow, each with 64 hidden channels and 3×3 kernels (stride 1, zero padding 1). Layer 1 takes the folded frame; layer 2 takes layer 1's new hidden state. Hidden and cell states start at zero for every video. A 1×1 convolution maps layer 2's hidden state from 64 to 16 channels, then `pixel_shuffle(4)` and a sigmoid give back a $1 \times 64 \times 64$ frame.

Each ConvLSTM layer $\ell \in \{1, 2\}$, with input u_τ, computes

$$
\begin{aligned}
[\, i,\ f,\ o,\ g\,] &= \mathsf{Conv}_{3\times 3}\left[\, u_\tau,\ h_{\tau-1}^{(\ell)}\,\right], \\
c_\tau^{(\ell)} &= \sigma(f) \odot c_{\tau-1}^{(\ell)} + \sigma(i) \odot \tanh(g), \\
h_\tau^{(\ell)} &= \sigma(o) \odot \tanh(c_\tau^{(\ell)}),
\end{aligned}
$$

where $[\cdot, \cdot]$ is channel concatenation and one convolution produces all four gates. For layer 1, $u_\tau^{(1)}$ is the folded frame; for layer 2, $u_\tau^{(2)} = h_\tau^{(1)}$. Each layer has its own weights. All convolutions use a learnable bias and PyTorch's default initialisation. No normalisation, dropout, or residual connections are added. Model A has exactly 480,784 trainable parameters.

Rollout. The network runs for 9 steps. For $\tau = 1, \ldots, 5$, the input u_τ is the τ-th input frame; for $\tau = 6, \ldots, 9$, it is the network's own previous prediction $\hat{x}_\tau$. The outputs of steps 5–9 form $\hat{Y} = (\hat{x}_6, \ldots, \hat{x}_{10})$; the outputs of steps 1–4 are thrown away. No teacher forcing is used: true future frames are never fed to the network, and gradients flow through the fed-back predictions.

Training and evaluation

Model A is trained with Adam (learning rate 10^{-3}, no schedule), batch size 32, for 30 epochs, keeping the final-epoch weights. One epoch is one pass over the 8,000 training videos in shuffled order, with one randomly sampled window per video ($t \in \{1, \ldots, 11\}$ at normal speed). The loss is squared error between prediction and target, averaged over the pixels and the available target frames of each video, then averaged over the videos in the batch. Every model is trained with seeds 0 and 1; each entry is reported as mean(seed 0, seed 1). The model was trained on an NVIDIA GeForce RTX 5060 Ti GPU (16 GB memory).

Q2.3: Reach of model A

Model A's reach (the largest distance, in original pixels, that information can travel through the network in one time step) is 8 pixels. The reasoning:

1. `pixel_unshuffle(4)` maps each 4×4 patch to one cell of the 16×16 folded grid. One cell corresponds to 4 original pixels (centre-to-centre); the patch width itself is not added.
2. A 3×3 spatial convolution on the folded grid lets information move from a cell to any of its 8 neighbours, i.e. by one cell = 4 original pixels in each direction. The 1×1 output convolution, `pixel_unshuffle` and `pixel_shuffle` do not move information.
3. Within one time step τ, consider all paths through the spatial convolutions from the new input u_τ or from the previous states $h_{\tau-1}^{(1)}$, $h_{\tau-1}^{(2)}$ to the prediction $\hat{x}_{\tau+1}$:
   - $u_\tau \to$ ConvLSTM layer 1 (3×3 conv) $\to$ ConvLSTM layer 2 (3×3 conv): $+4 + 4 = 8$ pixels

- $h_{\tau-1}^{(1)} \to$ ConvLSTM layer 1 (3×3 conv) $\to$ ConvLSTM layer 2 (3×3 conv): $+4 + 4 = 8$ pixels
- $h_{\tau-1}^{(2)} \to$ ConvLSTM layer 2 (3×3 conv): $+4$ pixels

The longest path determines the reach.

4. Total: 8 original pixels per time step.

Model A performance

	MSE_1	MSE_2	MSE_3	MSE_4	MSE_5	$E^{(5)}$	Params
Model A	0.0166 (0.0170, 0.0161)	0.0203 (0.0209, 0.0197)	0.0227 (0.0234, 0.0220)	0.0246 (0.0253, 0.0239)	0.0264 (0.0270, 0.0257)	0.0221 (0.0227, 0.0215)	480784
Blank	0.0426	0.0426	0.0426	0.0426	0.0426	0.0426	0
Copy-last	0.0492	0.0604	0.0669	0.0708	0.0732	0.0641	0

Table 2. Per-horizon MSE and $E^{(5)}$ on the 1,000 test videos for model A and the two untrained reference predictors ($1\times$, $t = 1$). Model A entries are mean (seed 0, seed 1); parameters are trainable parameter counts.

On the RTX 5060 Ti, training took 4.46 s per epoch (mean over all 30 epochs; both seeds). Inference on all 1,000 test videos at batch size 32 took 0.313 s for seed 0 and 0.318 s for seed 1 under `model.eval()` and `torch.no_grad()`, starting after each batch was on the device.

Q2.4: Comparison and error growth

Model A performs well relative to both baselines, and its error grows smoothly with the prediction horizon.

From Table 2, model A's mean per-horizon MSE rises from 0.0166 at horizon 1 to 0.0264 at horizon 5, while the baseline errors are much larger and flatter. The untrained blank baseline sits at $E^{(5)} = 0.0426$, and the copy-last baseline at $E^{(5)} = 0.0641$; model A achieves $E^{(5)} = 0.0221$ on average over the two seeds, roughly half the error of Blank and about a third of the error of Copy-last.

The per-horizon MSE goes up steadily with the horizon, which is what I expected: each predicted frame depends on the previous predictions, so errors can build up over the five frames. The gap to the baselines shows that the ConvLSTM is learning something useful, rather than just predicting a constant or copying the last frame.

This also fits the reach estimate in Q2.3. At horizon 5 the prediction has been built through five steps, and each step can only move information by at most 8 pixels, so the error has more time to build up. The fact that the error is still small (roughly 0.02) at horizon 5, compared with 0.04-0.07 for the baselines, suggests that two stacked 3×3 convolutions (reach 8 pixels) are enough to track a digit at normal speed, which matches the $1\times$ prediction in Q2.5.

In the overlapping test video, model A's prediction gets worse while the digits cross. The two blobs merge into one blob, and the model does not separate them again in the displayed forecast window. I think this is because the model is trained with squared error. When the digits overlap, it cannot tell which digit will come out on which side, so it predicts something like the average of the possible futures. The result is a blur rather than a clear prediction.

Q2.5: Predictions before running experiments

Before running any experiment in Testing the Baseline, my predictions are:

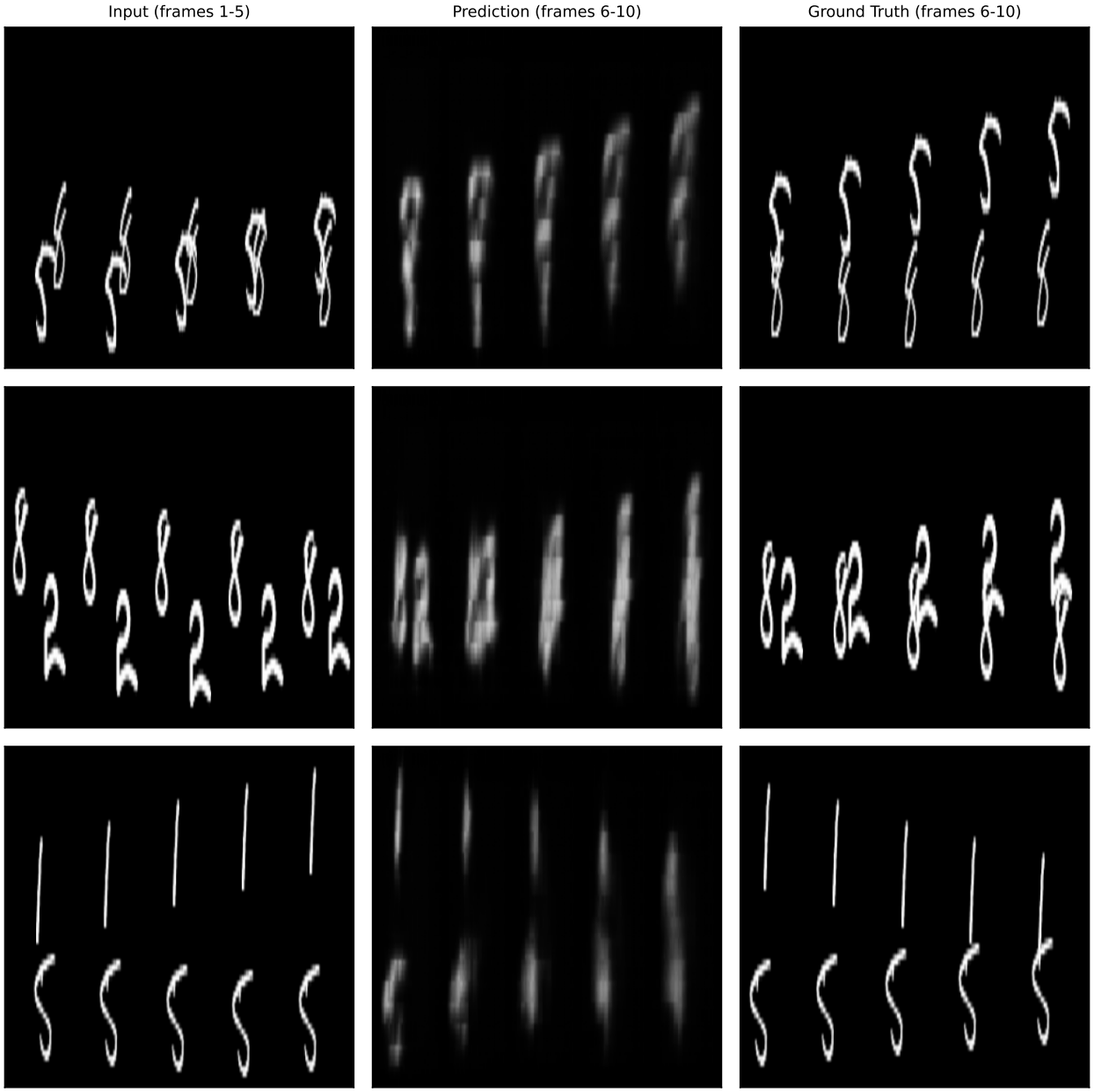


Figure 2. Input, prediction and ground truth for three test videos from model A (seed 0), including one video with overlapping digits (video index 9001 in panel 2).

- **Mirror:** I expect Model A to fail. It has only seen upright digits, and a mirrored digit looks different. I think the filters may have learned the shape of the digits as well as their motion, so a flipped digit may not match what they expect.
- **Rotation:** I expect Model A to fail too. Rotation changes the digit shape even more than mirroring, and the model has not seen rotated digits in training.
- **Speed:** The reach is 8 pixels per step, and the normal speed is about 3.32 pixels/frame (Figure 1). At $1\times$ the digit moves less than the reach, so the model should be fine. At $2\times$ it moves about 6.64 pixels/frame, which is still below 8 but close, so it might start to fail. At $3\times$ it moves about 9.96 pixels/frame, which is more than the reach, so the model cannot connect the old and new position in one step and should break down.